

THE ROLE OF STUDENTS IN ATTAINMENT OF SDG4

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What is the key to a nation's economic, social, and cultural development? Lucio Tan (n.d.), a renowned Filipino businessman, once said: *'We cannot, as a country, improve economically, socially, and culturally without quality education.'* Quality education is a critical factor in a country's development.

According to the United Nations, achieving inclusive and equitable quality education for all is at the heart of Sustainable Development Goal 4 (SDG4), which aims to ensure that every individual has access to lifelong learning opportunities. However, achieving this goal is a complex task that requires the engagement of all stakeholders, including students.

This prompts a question about the role students play in achieving the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goal 4. Thus, in this essay, I will explore the historical context that led to the development of SDG4, highlighting its significance as a global initiative aimed at ensuring inclusive and equitable quality education for all. Additionally, I will examine the crucial role that students play in attaining SDG4 and discuss various ways in which they can actively contribute to this important goal.

The Historical Context That Led to the Development of Sustainable Development Goal

4

The evolution of SDG4 was shaped by global trends such as cross-border migration, the rise of knowledge economies, and advances in information technology. The Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) from 2000 to 2015 included a focus on universal primary education, reflecting the growing importance of education in international development. Despite significant progress, inequalities persisted, and studies revealed challenges in student learning outcomes post-MDGs. These findings paved the way for the Sustainable Development Goals in 2015, emphasizing inclusive and quality education for all as a fundamental priority for global development from 2015 to 2030 (Kuroda & Nakasato, 2023).

The development of SDG4 on ensuring inclusive and equitable quality education and promoting lifelong learning opportunities for all can be traced back to the evolution of three fundamental approaches to international education development: *the peace approach*, *the human rights approach*, and *the development approach*. These approaches form the foundation of SDG4 (Ibid).

These three approaches informed the development of the MDGs in 2000, which included a goal on achieving universal primary education. SDG4, adopted in 2015 as part of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, builds upon the MDGs and expands the scope of education to encompass lifelong learning opportunities and address issues like gender equality and quality education.

The Significance of Ensuring Inclusive and Equitable Quality Education for All

Education is the process of facilitating learning. Quality education ensures that students acquire essential knowledge, skills, values, and attitudes to thrive in a rapidly changing world. It promotes critical thinking, creativity, problem-solving, communication, and collaboration skills, preparing individuals to navigate challenges, make informed decisions, and contribute positively to society (UNESCO, 2021).

Education is at the root of this SDG, which aims to ensure education for all, starting from basic education. Specific objectives include providing more opportunities for technical and vocational training to youth and adults so they can get better jobs; ending inequality in educational opportunities between men and women; providing the right education for children with disabilities, indigenous people and victims of conflict; improving school facilities to provide a safe and positive environment for everyone; increasing the number of trained and qualified teachers and promoting education for sustainable development (Ibid).

Inclusive and equitable quality education is not only a moral obligation, but also a prerequisite for sustainable development. By ensuring that all individuals have access to education that respects and meets their unique needs, we can foster social cohesion, economic growth, industry, innovation, and infrastructure, and promote peace and stability. Inclusive education unlocks the potential of individuals, preparing them to fully participate in society and contribute to solving global challenges. Ultimately, inclusive education is the foundation upon which a more just, prosperous, and inclusive world can be built (Tonegawa, 2023: pp 59 – 61).

The Crucial Role That Students Play in Attaining SDG4

Students play a vital role in achieving SDG4, the goal of quality education for all. Their perspectives, actions, and aspirations have the power to drive change and shape educational systems. They are not just recipients of education, but active agents of change, who can bring about transformative progress towards SDG4. Thus, the crucial roles that students play in attaining SDG4 include self-development, advocating for change, inventiveness and visionary thinking, and active participation in decision-making.

The first crucial role that students play in attaining SDG4 is developing oneself. Self-development, in the context of SDG4 (Quality Education), refers to the ongoing process of enhancing one's knowledge, skills, and abilities to achieve personal growth. It encompasses formal education, informal learning experiences, and skill-building activities aimed at expanding individuals' capabilities and potential. Self-development is a prerequisite for helping others and contributing to the success of others. When individuals prioritize their own personal growth, they are better equipped to support and contribute to the success of others. Thus, In the context of SDG4, this mean that students who can develop their own skills and knowledge can then use their expertise to help others learn and succeed.

“Advocating for change” is another important role that students play in attaining SDG4. “Advocating for change” refers to the process of actively promoting and supporting efforts to bring about positive transformations in policies, practices, or systems within a particular context. It involves raising awareness about pressing issues, mobilizing support, and influencing decision-makers to address challenges and implement solutions that lead to sustainable change. In relation to SDG4, this includes advocating for improved access to education, better quality of education, research writing to create new knowledge, publishing policy briefs and articles on a range of education issues including gender and disability inclusion, taking part in research and data collection efforts that can help improve education systems, and more. The main objective of advocating for change entails that students can help to influence policies that affect education and ultimately make a positive impact on the achievement of SDG4 (UNESCO, 2024).

Next, it is crucial to highlight that another crucial role that students play in attaining SDG4 is through inventiveness and visionary thinking. The two terms “*Inventiveness*” and “*visionary thinking*” are both creative processes that involve the generation of new ideas (McKinney, 2023). However, there are some distinct differences between the two. Therefore,

from my perspective, inventiveness is focused on finding solutions for existing problems, while visionary thinking focuses on anticipating future problems and finding solutions for them. Inventiveness and visionary thinking are both crucial role of students in achieving the SDG4 goal of quality education for all. For example, students can use their creativity and technical skills to create innovative educational technologies, such as mobile apps, interactive learning platforms, and culturally relevant educational games. These solutions can address specific problems in the students' communities, such as limited access to educational resources or language barriers. In summary, students' inventiveness and visionary thinking play a vital role in driving progress in education, and most importantly, advancing the goals of SDG4, which aim to provide inclusive and equitable education for all.

Finally, an equally significant role that students play in attaining SDG4 is the need for “active participation in decision-making.” The term "active participation in decision-making" refers to students' engagement in decisions that affect their education and learning environment. Students play a crucial role in the decision-making process related to education. By participating in school boards, student councils, and other decision-making bodies, students can have a direct impact on policies and programs that affect their learning. In addition, students can be involved in curriculum development, ensuring that the curriculum is relevant to their needs and interests. Thus, through their active participation, students can help to ensure that education policies are developed and implemented in a fair and effective way, leading to improved educational outcomes for all. (Bergmark & Westman, 2018).

Conclusion

Without any doubt, students play a crucial role in achieving Sustainable Development Goal 4, the goal of quality education for all. Their perspectives, actions, and aspirations are key drivers of change, and their involvement in decision-making and innovation is essential to making real progress towards this goal. Thus, it is crucial to create environments where students can develop themselves, advocate for change, and meaningfully contribute to the education system. By supporting and empowering students, we can make progress towards a world where everyone has access to quality education and the opportunities it provides.

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